The Overreaching Effects of Technology: *Technocracy, Behavior Modification and Social Alienation Against Democracy.*

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Abstract

This paper shows how in today´s new media spheres the social praxis is shifting towards passivity and "the bystander attitude" might be a result of the new sphere of alienation brought by Surveillance Capitalism as shown by Zuboff in her book by the same name.

> "The most profound technologies are those that disappear. They weave themselves into the fabric of everyday life until they are indistinguishable from it."
>
> (Mark Weiser "The Computer for the Twenty-First Century", Scientific American, 1991, pp. 66–75)

1. Introduction

We are living in a world that increasingly does not reflect the reality and conditions of existence of most human beings. Indeed, as Debord shows in *The Society of The Spectacle*, everything that was once a real life-experience is being reduced to the arena of virtual representations (Debord 15) and "rendered" into data (Zuboff 233, 2019). In many ways, today´s *information age* distinguishes itself from any previous social organisations and societal apparatus we have hitherto encountered. From the development of Debord decrying the emergence of a "*spectacular* world" to Baudrillard´s analysis of reality best seen as a combination of "*simulacra* in *Simulacra and Simulation* in 1981 -a real without origin or reality model" - and of reality whose "map [now] precedes the territory" (Baudrillard 11, 1981), we can today well perceive those changes in the latest social, cultural and economic developments happening in the Western World. In the late years of the Trump presidency, of the Covid-19 Crisis and of racial tensions and of uprisings provoked by the killing of George Floyd, the sense of a reality to grasp and handle correctly has been slowly dissolving and the idea of a *democratic and social Contract* presented first by Rousseau in 1762 in *The Social Contract*, seems to be imploding vis-à-vis those unforeseen situations. I will try in this paper to explore these phenomena: posing that the underlying crisis in the world today reflects the broader change in our apprehension of reality. Indeed, through new means of communication introduced by the predominance of social media, Big Data, and "*Big Other*" (Zuboff 143, 2019) that form *Surveillance Capitalism*, as shown by Zuboff in her magistral book by the same name (2019), our sense of reality has been seriously altered and is today pushed towards uncharted territories. Indeed, who sways today the direction the world takes? Or who controls the way all the data collected by online providers are used? But before further due, I must say that this thesis will rely heavily on Zuboff´s book as it is one of the most important books on the subject at the present time. Indeed, as Zuboff shows *Surveillance Capitalism* has changed the rules of the influence game: by collecting so much data about our online behaviour, major internet corporations have the means today to both

alter our sense of reality and to profit from the manufactured sense of that reality – a power that no one has ever possessed before (at least not to that extent). In this essay, I want to address this broader perspective and ask if the "bystander attitude" towards climate change, social changes and economic changes can be explained through Zuboff´s theoretical conceptualization of *Surveillance Capitalism*- and if her approach rightly reflects the alienation of the people and the suppression of their social means of action (praxis). The concept of alienation has used by Karl Marx actually shows how the individual (subject) is estranging himself from the product of his work and daily activities(object); this concept was also extended by Melvin Seeman in showing that a social alienation was also at play within the capitalist system furthering the isolation of the individual and his or her separation from the large society (Crossman 2019). In that sense, are we becoming today only spectators of social events and only related to them through our smart devices that shape our perceptions more than we expect? The latest protests and uprisings worldwide started by the death of George Floyd could at first sight invalidate such a view by reinforcing the importance and potency of visual and virtual stimuli that spark social praxis and movements. This view, however, should be attuned to the current age deemed by many as one of *post-truths, fake news,* and of constant "*spectacles"*. Certainly, new ways of influence and perception are at play here and this essay will try to show it.

I will first try to give an overview of societies latest cultural and sociological developments in the light of the Covid-19- an event that has changed the direction of this essay as first intended. I will then talk about the concept of *hypernormalisation,* a concept from Alexei Yurchack and used by Adam Curtis in a documentary by the same name (2016). This chapter will deal with the concept of disinformation in the age of fake news, "the triumph of the stupid", and the age of simulation and "*hyperreality*". I will then tie this background to the larger question of passivity, of "The Spectator Syndrome", which means being a by-stander vis-à-vis major societal events. I will try in this chapter to see how it impacts our social praxis. The core of this essay will try to answer this broader concern with the help of Zuboff´s concepts of *Surveillance Capitalism, Big Other,* and with the way she shows that "the means of knowledge are being slowly privatized" (Zuboff 180) by the precursors of *Surveillance Capitalism*. We will see with the help of Zuboff how this new apparatus is implementing "*means of behaviour modification*" (Zuboff 292) that could deeply shape a "perfectly alienated" citizen. This larger chapter will try to answer my thesis question and show in what ways our freedom of choice is being endangered by this "new division of learning" (Zuboff

182). In conclusion, we will see how social media and the precursors of *Surveillance Capitalism* play a role in building a "overconnected cage" that is diametrically opposed to the social praxis, the social movements, and the democratic contracts that bind our societies. We will see that this new apparatus might be one possible cause for the destruction of democratic institutions. Finally, we will see that more broadly, inequality of wealth, knowledge and resources are constituents of this apparatus and will only spark more tensions in the years that will be defined by the worst economic depression since the Great Depression of 1929.

2. The Coronavirus Crisis: a sign of a systemic change in the social fabric?

> "If the humanization of the oppressed signifies subversion, so also does their freedom; hence the necessity for constant control. And the more the oppressors control the oppressed the more they change them into apparently inanimate "things." This tendency of the oppressor consciousness to "in-animate" everything and everyone it encounters, in its eagerness to possess, unquestionably corresponds with a tendency to sadism. "(Paulo Freire, Pedagogy of The Oppressed, pp.59, 1970)

As Zuboff shows in her Book *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*, Durkheim wrote in 1893 in *The Division of Labour in Society* that changes do not occur in society because the economy shifts from an industrially-directed society to a more service-based society; but because the needs of its people change (Durkheim, in Zuboff, p.32, 2019). It is interesting to take Durkheim´s view here as it is true that today´s human beings´ behaviour has undergone many developments as Zuboff shows: from being an exploited individual drown in a larger social structure to becoming a more and more "*individualized*" subject (Zuboff,35). In that sense, we would think that the individual today controls the way society evolves, as his or her "needs" supposedly direct the movements of society and its larger developments. However, in my opinion, this view does not today fully reflect the latest development in the U.S.A and in the world at large. I would argue that individuals are rather more and more atomized, alienated, manipulated and lured into a virtual world where a pseudo-individual sense of freedom and praxis is created by the precursors of Surveillance Capitalism who increasingly own and control the trajectories of our needs. Whereas Durkheim believed that "our needs" were the drivers of changes in society; today, they are more and more manufactured and sent back to us as if they were our own, making societal changes- a "top-down" project rather than a democratic one. In that sense, let's take the

corona crisis as a social experiment: to what extent can the people be inclined to believe in an invisible threat; and, if so, restrict their day-to-day movements because of it? Does the mental image formed by a possible threat hold more power in that sense than the physical and potential deadly outcomes? One may give different answers according to someone´s morality, values or rationality. But what is really striking here is that in many cases, people will be attuned all around the world to a virtual image-a non-visible threat- thanks to the media. Here we can think of the concept of "*the global village*" by McLuhan (Understanding Media, 1964), where everything is interconnected, and time and space are abolished in technology. Indeed, here we see that "our needs" are but interlinked in this new media sphere that makes the world seems like an interconnected village as McLuhan stated. As a video by the cyber-activist group Anonymous points rightly (2020), the Covid-19 situation might be close to a social ritual and quoting the artist Sharon Devlin, they state that a ritual is a

> Method to alter one's mind, a sacred drama in which you are the audience as well as the participants, where you activate parts of the mind that are not activated by everyday activity. (Devlin in Dykes 2020)

According to them, the new situation emerging from the Covid-19 crisis might be one that firstly "destroys the old ego/individual self" and secondly enforces "liminal changes"- a proper shift in the way we apprehend reality. The social activist and writer, Naomi Klein, actually talked about such a method in her book *The Shock Doctrine* (2007) showing that an emotional and intellectual situation of stress might be often used to push certain policies. In that sense, it would be delusional not to understand that the underlying condition of Covid-90, one of confinement at home, has reinforced the dependency of one to his or her online and virtual world. Even without descending into conspiracies, the question of whether this new situation might be the reflection of a larger paradigm shift or not is interesting. Correlatively, as Marshall Bergmann shows in 1981 in *All that Is Solid Melts into Air*, the control of the streets and public outdoors space has always been an important factor in the control of the citizens. Indeed, the public squares or streets is a place of meeting for multiple humans that enable them to raise concerns over a governments policy via protests, gathering or social interactions. As Paulo Freire shows in *The Pedagogy of The Oppressed* the aspect of a real revolution in ideas and behaviours passes by the dialogues and its enacting active purpose (Freiere 101). By restraining citizens to be able to meet and forcing them to rely on an overreaching virtual and online apparatus, citizens are unable to enact a concrete social praxis that would enable them to question and modify the inherent structure of capitalism.

In opposition to that, a reconnection with the earth, the natural space and public space is more needed than ever; but in a world that is more and more happening online, questions about the way we interact, define our common purposes and create our individuality need to be addressed. In that sense, the question of whether the Covid-19 crisis depending on its length and impacts will change the social fabric for the worse or not, is a salient one. On the other hand, someone could argue the opposite: as we just experienced, the visual experience of the death of George Floyd is a striking event that highlights our dependency to the visual. Int that sense, almost 99 % of the "generation Z" and millennials in the U.S.A possess a smartphone and an internet connection as Gilhooly shows by pointing to a study by Poushter (2016). Today, the ubiquity of internet communication and how we relay online information have changed many things and many are still adapting to it (e.g. Trump´s tweets). We face today the same perplexities already perceived by McLuhan in 1967: "in the name of progress our official culture is striving to force the new media to do the work of the old." (Mcluhan 94). In that sense, the death of Floyd might just be the beginning of a new era: where the consumption of "visual information (*spectacle*)" is the new norm. This might have many implications: one might ask if the visual and the virtual will hold more power than the social praxis and the physical encounter in the future? When we look to the latest protests of Black Lives Matters all around the world, this view could however be contested: a survey by the *Pew Research Center* shows that two-thirds of the U.S. population support the Black Lives Matters movement[1]. But here it is interesting to point to the fact that the issue of racial tension has been there for a long time, and one might see the dominance of the media as having an important role in shifting attitudes. In that sense, the protests and uprisings that have been happening since the Covid-19 crisis and the death of Floyd (social movements in general) need to be analysed in a new light: "what if social reality is today influenced mainly by the virtual?**"** I will try to answer some of these questions in the next chapter and try to highlight the issues in such a visual and virtual domination.

3. Hypernormalization, Fake News and Disinformation: The Triumph of The Stupid.

"The discovery of the alphabet will create forgetfulness in the learners' souls, because they will not use their memories; they will trust to the external written

[1] https://www.pewsocialtrends.org/2020/06/12/amid-protests-majorities-across-racial-and-ethnic-groups-express-support-for-the-black-lives-matter-movement/

> characters and not remember of themselves. Your invention is not an aid to memory…you give your disciples not truth, but only the semblance of truth; they will be the hearers of many things and they will learn nothing." (Socrates, Pheadrus in McLuhan, 1967, p. 113)

In *The Medium is the Massage*, McLuhan shows that the dominant form of communication and comprehension in the pre-alphabet society was the "hearing capability". The arrival of the alphabet changed that with the visual becoming the predominant way by which a medium works: in "spatiality and visuality" (McLuhan 44). McLuhan continues by stating that any form of rationality was based on "the line, the presentation of connected and sequential facts or concepts" but in 1967 he would state that the visual world was not the "primary" force anymore (McLuhan 45). By that, he meant what he had previously written in 1964 in his book *Understanding Media- The Extension of Man*: technology is merely an extension of the capability of the individual, where the message delivered is less important than the characteristic of the medium itself that changes the individual interaction to his or her world. Today, we see that this technology has incorporated the individual itself as he or she is the main "rendered" of data information as shown by Zuboff (pt.2; chap.4-5). As the main providers of data information, individuals increasingly shift the way we apprehend reality and how it is composed. As we will see throughout this essay, the individualization of our social interactions is one reason for the current passivity vis-à-vis climate change. The problem of our age lies in who produces the information, to what extent it is incorporated into our lives, and what might be its lasting effect on our society. In *Empire of Illusion* (2010), a book that foretells the advent of what I called "the Triumph of the Stupid", Hedges shows that one of the reasons for this advent might be connected to what McLuhan developed throughout his book: that memory and literacy is slowly disappearing under the visual. For example, as many as 80% of American families did not read a book in 2007 (Hedges 44). Hedges also shows using the *Princeton Review* number that the educational level of presidential debates has almost decreased from half of its level since the 1858 Lincoln-Douglas´s debate and he is not even talking about Trump´s educational level that went even further down during the last election (Hedges 45). This trend confirms what we saw in the first chapter and shows that what we experience today is evading old framework of thoughts: a world where the visual and "spectacular" are overtaking literacy. Indeed, today words are more condensed in writing SMS, or even the written words are being replaced by voice messages, far from literacy and its descriptions. In that sense, the documentarist Adam

Curtis in his documentary *HyperNormalization* (2016) tries to explain that the void created by the disappearance of literacy has been filed by disinformation and because of its ubiquity, we are getting used to it and reaching a sense of hypernormality (Berghel 2020). As Hedges shows quoting Deresiewicz, today's society has been changed by the apparition of the camera that has led to "a culture of celebrity" and by the apparition of the computer that has created a "culture of connectivity"; "the contemporary self is being validated by its visibility" on social media (Hedges 22-23). Figures like Trump or Kanye West have embodied this sense of **self-referentiality** and **narcissism** in the communication sphere. Self-referentiality broadly means what McLuhan explained with his famous concept "The medium is the message", meaning that the message (information) is superseded by the medium (platform) and become less important that the latter one. In that sense, we could interpret the advent of fake news as exactly that: news that is only important because of its effect and not its intrinsic content/value. Hedges actually names fake news "pseudo- events", events that have been "manufactured" and are "staged" for the purpose of "entertainment or sensationalism" (Hedges 48-49). The creation of fake news becomes a business like any other:

> They do not explain reality, as stereotypes attempt to, but replace reality. Pseudo-events redefine reality by the parameters set by their creators. These creators, who make massive profits selling illusions, have a vested interest in maintaining the power structures they control. (Hedges 51)

As Zuboff shows the problem of "fake news" is actively linked to the logic of Surveillance Capitalism as its way of thriving and making more profits rely mainly on the extraction of online customers behaviour data whatever the content shared is. Indeed, as a fake story might attract more attention, it is a great source of collection of customers data, which are then sold to third parties. For example, Zuboff shows that videos posted on Facebook are being shared the most and produce the most data for Facebook. In that sense, relaying knowledge absolutely processes from a sense of "radical indifference" in Surveillance Capitalism (Zuboff 512). What Zuboff means by that is the fact that the logic of data accumulation, the "equivalence without equity", and the "behavioural surplus" logic push the precursors of this system to disregard any regulations for the sake of possessing more information about the online behaviours of its users and for the sake of increasing their profits in that sense. Here information is not important anymore as it becomes self-referential, just another commodity and data drowned in the larger ocean of surveillance capitalism (Zuboff 377).

In a broader sociological sense, we could also link this process of self-referentiality to larger governmental projects of *hypernormalization*. This concept was coined by Alexei Yurchak, a Russian anthropologist, in his book *Everything Was Forever, Until It Was No More: The Last Soviet Generation (2006)* where he explains how the Soviet system of the 70s-80s was not working but everyone was pretending the opposite by adhering to self-fulfilling prophecy to maintain the status quo. In that sense, it is interesting to see how disinformation works at a governmental level. Using Yurchak´s concept, Curtis shows in his documentary by the same name, how the world has become hyper-normalized and how the complexity of reality is being reduced to a purely apparent and autotelic content. For Curtis, producers of information in our age have managed to normalize disinformation in two ways: by "perception management" and by "constructive ambiguity". As Andrew explains in an article for Trebuchet magazine (2018), the first one is*:*

> a Propaganda technique that involves carefully altering the perceptions of a target audience to suit the objectives of the sponsor[…]selective information is provided (or denied) to a target audience to influence their emotions, motives and objective reasoning in order to promote a change in behaviour that is favourable to the sponsor. (Department of Defense (2001) in Andrew 2018)

While the second one is:

> a negotiation technique first employed in the 1970s by Henry Kissinger, it is premised on the belief that ambiguously worded text can create opportunities for advancing the interests of both parties to a negotiation.(Khaled Elgindy, 'When Ambiguity is Destructive' Brookings Edu, 2014 in Andrew 2018)

We see here that according to Curtis disinformation has been a calculated governmental shift in the way information is delivered to us. We will see in the next chapter that the emergence of Surveillance Capitalism has only further increased the divide between facts, perception management and propaganda. In that sense, Berghel, a sociologist, shows quoting Jamieson that this situation where "activated cynicism depresses learning" (Jamieson 29 in Berghel 81) might be another explanation for the emergence of a sense of disbelief and disenchantment in the news. As we have seen in the U.S.A, Trump has increasingly been labelling the press as "fake news" and has played within that framework. As Will Alexander, a journalist, writes in an article from 2017, "fake news" has been a subject of discussion since Thomas Jefferson´s presidency, as he was decrying the news and pushing people to

avoid news media. But here the question is not so much about the news and the way it is constantly discredited but about how the political and social conversation has changed. Berghel actually shows by using McNamee and Jamieson´s approaches that there are two ways of approaching this issue: McNamee actually believes that social media are there "to control the political conversation (McNamee in Berghel 79); and Jamieson believes that social media actually change "the body politic" in many ways (e.g. perception managements, social engineering, and microtargeting) and create new forms of "tribalism" (religious, racial, ethnic, ultranationalist, etc…) (Jamieson in Berghel 79). Berghel also shows that Jamieson explains the 2016 U.S. election disinformation campaigns by studying closely on how they can be a powerful tool "for engaging and energizing tribes" and how they usually are not impended by any "political or legal penalty"(Jamieson in Berghel 81). It is not hard to see parallels today with the current state of affairs in the U.S.A: indeed, the emergence of the Alt-right has been something that has greatly relied on a new way of manipulating social media (Tweeter) and creating a counter-political force outside of mainstream medias routes (Youtube).

What is at stake here is not only the disturbance that social media have on democratic institutions and on social praxis, but also the formation of what Baudrillard called the **hyperreal** and its multiple simulations of reality (Baudrillard 120). Baudrillard actually follows the concept of McLuhan "the medium is the message" but furthers it by stating that today the information does not produce meaning anymore (Baudrillard 121). Indeed, he sees in the overproduction of meanings a "necessary tool of socialization": for him, who does not communicate today is treated as a "dissocialized pariah" (Baudrillard 120). For him the hyperreal means a loss of meaning as the production of meaning does not create a communication anymore but instead is part of "a larger mise-en-scène" (Baudrillard 121). We can see here that everyone today is part and creator of information and meaning, staging oneself on Instagram, holding videoconference on YouTube, or being a celebrity star and ending up as "The Leader of the Free World"(itself a form of propaganda from the "Cold War"). This other side of the production of pseudo-events and sensationalism pushes for a different perception of social reality. Indeed, who is a meaningful informational voice when everyone can produce meaning and stage its own appreciation of reality? Where is the model to follow or who produces the best simulation? It is truth that people have more and more access to technologies and that the demographics also push for an increase in the amount of information produce, but the fact that today everyone can pretend to be an expert might be a

problem(e.g. the Covid-19 crisis). In that sense, what Baudrillard means by simulation would be a pseudo-reality that actually affects and deregulates the whole system of meaning. But it is interesting here to note this new tendency on social platforms and see who is taken as a model to follow or disregarded. Marshall McLuhan actually wrote about the danger of the palliative narcissist use of social media:

> The Greek myth of Narcissus is directly concerned with a fact of human experience, as the word Narcissus indicates. It is from the Greek word narcosis, or numbness. The youth Narcissus mistook his own reflection in the water for another person. This extension of himself by mirror numbed his perceptions until he became the servomechanism of his own extended or repeated image. The nymph Echo tried to win his love with fragments of his own speech, but in vain. He was numb. He had adapted to his extension of himself and had become a closed system. (McLuhan, Understanding Media: The Extension of Man, 1964, p.41)

For McLuhan, narcissism in social media works only as a tool to "maintain the equilibrium of the system" overwhelmed by an overloaded informational system (McLuhan 41). Indeed, as we are at the centre of the information and her or his creator, the system can work in a close loop where nothing really adds up. Also, as we are overexposed to violent social events on social media, we tried to find a palliative tool- such as a closed system of reward and pleasure that "*numbs us*"- as McLuhan shows by explaining it is the actual etymology of narcissism (McLuhan 49). One of the most interesting ideas in this chapter called *The Gadget Lover* is that McLuhan linked the development of technology to a palliative tool and to its possible help or impact on social behaviours and social illnesses. This fact is indeed corroborated by psychologists. For example, Doctor Larry D. Rosen directed a study on 216 undergraduates' students about their phone use and found that most of the students were unlocking their phones roughly 60 times a day for 3-4 minutes, which is around four hours of phone use each day. Rosen actually links this use to "anxiety disorder- technology disorder and FOMO—fear of missing out". Rosen also concludes that we are being unable to switch off from this reality that encloses us. In turn, this leads for him to a decrease in our attention span: for Rosen, we are so used to technology that to deprive an individual from a smartphone might be unbearable and make his level of anxiety rise.(Rosen, *Are We All Becoming Pavlov's Dogs?* 2016) As Rosen states, technology is creating a kind of "Pavlovian addiction", where technology conditions us and create a sense of discipline and punishment/reward in the smartphone user. Addiction and psycho-somatic illnesses are still

being analysed as new emerging illnesses like the "phantom vibration"- where people think that their phone is ringing when it is not- are just being discovered because of the overuse of technology. This essay will explore in the two next chapters how those illnesses can impact a real social praxis and induce a sense of self-regulation in the individual. Suffice to say here, that self-referentiality and narcissism are part of "the fourth revolution" that "is blurring the lines between the physical, digital, and biological spheres." (Schwab ,2016) But we might need to reconsider the term Schwab used: "revolution". As one tech developers from Silicon Valley states in the Anonymous video mentioned before: "the more [technology/A. I] they know about us, the more we fall in love with them"; we need to research our dependency to new technology and how it might alienate us from each other and from our natural world. For example, a study for *the European Journal of Psychology* by Glăveanu and Kuiper (2018) shows that social comparison in the use of social media has an important role in the formation of the self of young adult women , this use pushes them to simulate their lives and could have negative impact for the construction of their identities. The next chapter will try to address this fact and see how we are becoming increasingly "spectators" and by-stander in front of a "staged reality".

4. Passivity, "The Spectator Syndrome": By-Standing Effect and Its Impact on The Social Praxis.

> By continuously embracing technologies, we relate ourselves to them as servomechanisms. That is why we must, to use them at all, serve these objects, these extensions of ourselves, as gods or minor religions.
>
> (Marshall McLuhan, Understanding Media: The Extension of Man, 1964, p.48)

Considering what McLuhan states, if we all act like actors and stage our reality: are we not becoming spectators of our lives? I want to develop this question and apply it to the climate debate: is it true that people are becoming increasingly "spectators" of the social and larger social structure at work here? And if the answer is positive, would it mean that the attitude towards climate change could be explained as resulting from a "bystander attitude"? By bystander, I mean someone who is watching a crime committed by others and do not react to it, because of the numbers of co-watchers. I will use here the insight of Gerdien De Vries, a Professor of Public Management and Organisation at Delft University of Technology, who first drew attention to this problem. For her the bystander effect is connected to climate change as it is:

> a critical situation that occurs while people stand by and watch…[a] psychological phenomena that can explain human inaction towards global warming on a regular basis. (DeVries, 2020)

Another definition, we will work with is the one of *attention* used by Davenport and Beck:

> Attention is a focused mental engagement on a particular item of information. Items come into our awareness, we attend to a particular item, and then we decide whether to act. (Davenport, Beck, 2001)

Indeed, how attentive/passive are the subjects today and to what kind of stimuli are they reactive to? To understand this process, let´s start at the end of the sixties when Guy Debord, a French writer, would write at length about what we experience today. In 1967, he wrote a seminal and very important book *The Society of the Spectacle*, in which he relates how the world stage slowly became a series of "spectacles" which create an alienating reality, where the "spectators" are cut from their social praxis and therefore alienated from themselves. Kaplan puts it well in his analysis of *the Society of the Spectacle*:

> In this new social reality, personal identity has shifted its location: no longer based in one's roles as citizen or worker with a practical involvement in the production of a shared social world, it instead has become centred in consumption and the vicarious satisfactions of identifying with stars and celebrities (Kaplan 463, 2012)

For Debord, the exploitation and alienation not only reside in the inability of the masses to possess the means of production and to revolt against the dominant class; but it is also a result of the separation between the individual and the collective praxis that constitutes our social reality. In other words, for Debord, the individual is condemned to be a spectator of the social reality, subject and object of the "spectacular world". This can be seen today in "the generation Z" that produces entrancing videos of themselves on social media and creates self-referential and narcissistic closed systems of mediation. As we have seen earlier with the excerpt from McLuhan about narcissism, the individual might react to an information overload through more consumption and will try to find a palliative in the media use. Kaplan analysing Debord´s concepts finds also a similar pattern, as being "a spectator" means for him that:

> The individual, though condemned to the passive acceptance of an alien everyday reality, is thus driven into a form of madness in which, by resorting to magical

> devices, he entertains the illusion that he is reacting to this fate. The recognition and consumption of commodities are at the core of this pseudo response to a communication to which no response is possible. The need to imitate that the consumer experiences is indeed a truly infantile need, one determined by every aspect of his fundamental dispossession (Kaplan 463, 2012)

In that excerpt, we see that Guy Debord also points out another problem by creating the concept of "spectacle": he points to the fact that the audience is more likely to act in a consumptive mode while responding to the overwhelming level of news, by imitation, without really knowing whether it's true or not. In that sense, we can think of Twitter or the irrational shares of information on the web. Not only do we consume the news, but we imitate others by seeing information being shared many times. According to a 2016 *Pew Researcher Centre's* survey, one in four US Americans said they would share "fake news", whether aware at the time of sharing it or not[2]. It is interesting to go back here to the term used by Kaplan to describe *The Society of the Spectacle- "*vicarious consumption" -because it highlights the current states of the news media structure: a global system where who (or what) is trending gets the most attention; or a system where something is likely to have a widespread audience because of its number of followers/ retweets. In *the Society of the Spectacle*, Debord describes general trends in the new contemporary spectacular world: the banalization of the news as a meaningful item and the displacement of all qualitative organic culture under the reign of the spectacle and the entertainment. But as Zuboff shows this poses a problem as democratic institutions implies our participation as democratic subjects. Indeed, the more we consume spectacles, and represent ourselves on social media the less we have control over our own data and the overall representation that constitutes the social fabric. She shows that the shift at the core of *Surveillance Capitalism* is that "*automated machine processes not only know our behaviour but also shape our behaviour at scale*." (Zuboff 8) Here we can ask whether Zuboff actually believes any subjectivity is left in this scheme or not. Zuboff actually sees the development of surveillance capitalism as a "dispossession system" where everything is rendered into data, she tells the example of Google Maps' founder that wants to create a tool to map the whole world and render it as data:

[2] http://www.journalism.org/2016/12/15/many-americans-believe-fake-news-is-sowing-confusion/pj_2016-12-15_fake-news_0-05/

> Fleisher intends to establish Google´s prerogative to empty every place of the subjective meanings that unite the human beings who gather there. Yes, when we leave our home, we know we will be seen, but we expect to be seen by one another in spaces that we choose. Instead, its´ all impersonal spectacle now. My house, my street, my neighbourhood, my favourite café: each is redefined as a living tourist brochure, surveillance target, and strip mine, an object for universal inspection and commercial expropriation. (Zuboff 141)

But if we are being watched, are we not staring into each other´s blank eyes and seeing social crisis, climate disasters and economic collapses as pure passive by-stander? Or are we as Zuboff says only cogs in a system of "behavioural surplus", disciplined to a kind of "*Neofeudalism"* as Zuboff shows by quoting Greenwood: "a consolidation of elite wealth and power far beyond the control of ordinary people and the mechanism of democratic consent."(Greenwood in Zuboff 44) If we analyse this passivity through the concept of "by-stander" or "the by-stander effect", as explained by Gerdien De Vries, it might be helpful. She shows quoting Fischer, Latané and Darley that this effect can be explained through "three psychological processes: diffusion of responsibility, evaluation apprehension, and pluralistic ignorance." (e.g., Fischer et al., 2011; Latané & Darley, 1970 in De Vries 2020) De Vries tells the same thing that we saw earlier: that "the diffusion of responsibility" is correlated to the fact that:

> the more bystanders there are, the less responsible we feel to take action, because we tend to divide our personal responsibility to take action by the number of bystanders. "(De Vries 2020)

This might be arguable as we have seen in the introduction with many people reacting to the death of George Floyd lately, but let´s move one to the second process- "the evaluation apprehension". According to De Vries, this process is:

> the fear of looking stupid when we perform public actions. In other words, we are afraid to make mistakes or act inadequately when we feel that others pay attention to us, which makes us more reluctant to act in critical situations. (De Vries 2020)

As Debord´s analysis showed, the vicarious consumption aspect of consuming the news tends to reinforce a merely mimetic involvement in the social praxis, one that might be inhibited by fashion, fear and superficial judgement. This is indeed one of the aspects that is

the most salient in the latest social movements we are experiencing: as the question of whether the "fashionable" aspect of news consumption and the reaction to it might actually have a bigger role to play than the fact of creating a properly organized and lasting social movement, Indeed, here further researches might show that movements like the hipster movement or veganism could corroborate this claim to some extent. The last process according to De Vries is connected to the "*pluralistic ignorance*":

> When we have to make sense of an ambiguous situation, we rely on the public reactions of others. If no one reacts, a bystander effect could occur because all people present believe that no one else perceives the situation as critical. (De Vries, 2020)

The two last points have been proved by a research from 2019 by Brittany Bloodhart, Janet K. Swim and Elaine Dicicco- that shows a correlation between the "framing of climate change information" as "emotionally negative" and a "lack of effectiveness". However, they show that this is where the conundrum lies:

> Consistent with this logic, respondents were less likely to prefer emotional over non-emotional framing of climate change messages. However, this preference may lead members of the public to suppress their emotions when communicating about climate change. (Bloodhart, K.Swin, Dicicco 2019)

Here might lie a possible reason for our alienated approach to climate change: a combination of the way news media is produced by people that are increasingly becoming both subjects and objects of news and are over-emotional and "spectacular" in their representation of dire social crisis; working in a kind of echo-chamber that works through vicarious consumption, fashionable news, fear and inhibition. In a lecture at the Freie Universität, Professor Dr. Lora Anne Viola pointed out rightly that what Foucault described in *Discipline and Punish* in 1975 as the "panopticon system" - a place where everyone is being watched without noticing it, therefore forcing a self-control on the "being watched"- might slowly be changing to something else. Because "social values" today emerge from individuals but are not redistributed to them through a genuine social praxis enacted collectively, I think we could argue here that we are noticing the end of "the panopticon system" and seeing the emergence of a society where every individual contributes to a general alienated, atomized and self-referential - "controlled society". This act of denying our active part in the composition of the social world should also be challenged economically. As today what constitutes any form of capital emerges from the people (their data- "behavioural surplus" Zuboff) but is used

against them. I will discuss in the next chapter this new shift in surveillance and if it implies a kind of behavioural modification that might forever change our democratic institutions.

5. Surveillance Capitalism, Big Data and "The Privatization in The Means of Learning": How Means of Behaviour Modification Have Created the Perfectly Alienated Citizen.

> Imagine two soundproof booths, one occupied by a man, the other by a woman, each typing at you, each trying to impersonate the other (a precursor to the current fun troubles with cyber-dating!). We then proceed to a booth with a man versus a booth with a machine. The claim of the Turing Test is that if you cannot tell the difference you have no scientific basis to claim a different status for people than for machines.(Jaron Lanier, Agents of Alienation, Journal of Consciousness Studies, 2, 1995, pp. 76–81)

What we have seen earlier is that the way human´s behaviour is changing with the use of social media and news technology might be far more overreaching that what we think at first. But is it so desperate and is technology only bringing alienation? Don't we have any freedom of choice and a free will or are we totally alienated? Zuboff has a chapter in her book that deals about the evolution of individual choices since the beginning of modernity. According to her, the "second modernity" is the capability of individuals to self-assert themselves and determine their place within the larger social fabric (Zuboff 36). But she shows that the capability of individual emancipation and individual creation is at risk since the neoliberal deregulation that started in the 70´s and that led place to economic imperatives- work without redistribution- a free market ideology where "the shareholders maximisation of profits" has taken over any public sense of deliberation and atomized the "public corporation"(Zuboff 41). In that sense, I think that today the individual must fight to find a third way to manage his affects as he or she feels trapped by the general system and suffers from a sense of helplessness that crushes her or him and does not enable him or her to change the system in meaningful ways anymore. Here comes the palliative uses of social media, as we have explained in the previous chapter. Also, Zuboff states that the fabric of democracy is also undermined by a new oligarchic order that uses its own capital resources

to increase its control over democratic institutions and to increase its capital (Zuboff 41-46). As Zuboff states, Picketty already explained this tendency in *The Capital in the Twentieth Century* (2017) where he shows that the rate of profits within the capitalist accumulation of wealth(revenues and interests) is bigger than the global economic growth, which tends to reinforce anti-democratic forces and obstruct the realization of a genuine social praxis (Zuboff 43). In that sense, what Zuboff wants to explain is that what she calls *Surveillance Capitalism* works as an apparatus that uses our data to influence us and to locate our political/ideological affiliation, she calls this phenomenon the capture of the" behavioural surplus": as most of our interactional movements are captured to build a precise profile of us that will be at the same time a source of profits and a controlling tool against us. (Zuboff 123) In that sense, our contemporary society as shown by Zuboff in her book is one that is shaped by *behaviour modification* and social alienation through the new uses of technologies by *Surveillance Capitalism*. (Zuboff, 2019, p.19) It is not only reshaping the way we think but the way we are able to think. "The division of learning" as shown by Zuboff is a process of asymmetrical knowledge and means of knowing. Indeed, technological advances in the information age enable the online providers to release what we consume or do not consume (for example, how our newsfeed displays certain information or how Google search works). In that sense, as it is not only the way we consume the news but the way we are consumed by it that seems to matter nowadays, we can rightly point to transformation in our cognitive and behavioural system accordingly. As behaviourists such as Pavlov showed early on (Conditioned Reflexes, 1926) , a certain stimulus implies a certain reaction and knowing how to process with a human behaviour accordingly points to a power of propaganda and conditioning of the "mind of the people" never reached before. The late Cambridge Analytica scandal has proven such a point: a situation where millions of people had their data collected on Facebook without their consent and had these data use against them for political gain (targeted advertising).With people constantly facing a mining of their data that will be used to shift their possible behaviour and political affiliation, Zuboff rightly points out in her book about our sacrificed right of sanctuary which will soon not exist anymore. Here, we can rightly point to the dangers faced by many in the light of the Covid-19 situation: as new system of tracking and tracing further diminish our privacy rights and our personal data protection. Overall, it is not so much about losing touch with one reality but about not being able to form one's sense of reality anymore. As internet providers and corporations have gathered so many data about our behaviours and could shift our behaviours accordingly. The

latest developments in that sense today only prove that capitalism has reached such a level of concentration that it starts to infiltrate all layers of society. Today, the destruction of democratic institutions is more salient than ever: our governments tend towards cronyism, oligarchy, mass conditioning and propaganda as the oligarchic elite reinvest its capital to shift the course of elections and democratic deliberations. Oligarchy is basically a system where a few people rue over the majority and political cronyism (also called nepotism) is a subsequent version of it where politicians are appointed or economically supported because they will be partial towards certain groups or political issues during their terms. If ever someone would have been so naïve as to pretend that the capitalist class would not reinvest its accumulated capital to change the platform on which it thrives, it is today far from reality. Indeed, today the capitalist class thrives on reducing any possible alternate ways to think within the capitalist system. In a sense, we have reached what we could call "a full-blown consumers society". Walking in the streets of Berlin these days, it is easy to see how the main arteries of the city now are only dedicated to a pure consumptive purpose: indeed, the new perspectives imposed by capitalism would be just to be a good consumer and to work towards it without question. Anyone is a consumer in a sense today and that is the only role they can fulfill as citizen in a place where everything is designed to make them consume more. Like "the proles" in Orwell´s 1984, today people are oblivious of the major schemes that are at play here as Zuboff tells in her book: by giving away their data in order to please their narcissistic impulses, they forget that they are ending up and forever trapped in a consumer feedback loop. Instead, people must be happy as "the plebs" in Huxley´s *Brave New World*[3] today as everything is calculated for them and sent back to them so they think they are actually satisfying their own desires when much to the opposite their desires are actually just induced unto them. I would want here to explore more of these physiological and psychological changes but for the sake of length, I will try to draw her a conclusion.

6. Conclusion: The New Age and The Destruction of Democratic Institution: Total Alienation.

[3] Within the next generation I believe that the world's rulers will discover that infant conditioning and narco-hypnosis are more efficient, as instruments of government, than clubs and prisons, and that the lust for power can be just as completely satisfied by suggesting people into loving their servitude as by flogging and kicking them into obedience.

Huxley, Aldous (2014-07-01). Brave New World. HarperCollins. Kindle Edition

> “Because, in the bottom of all our terrified souls, we all know that democracy is a dying giant, a sick, sick dying, decaying political concept, writhing in its final pain. I don't mean the United States is finished as a world power. The United States is the most powerful, the richest, the most advanced country in the world, light-years ahead of any other country. And I don't mean the Communists are going to take over the world. The Communists are deader than we are. What's finished is the idea that this great country is dedicated to the freedom and flourishing of every individual in it. It's the individual that's finished. It's the single, solitary human being who's finished. It's every single one of you out there who's finished. Because this is no longer a nation of independent individuals. This is a nation of two hundred odd million transistorized, deodorized, whiter- than-white, steel-belted bodies, totally unnecessary as human beings and as replaceable as piston rods.” (Howard, in the movie Network, 1976)

To conclude this essay, we have seen that everyone is more and more living in a “overconnected cage” that is diametrically opposed to the social praxis, the social movements, and the democratic contracts that bind our societies. As Zuboff shows the “division of learning” poses a threat to the people own possibilities of deliberation and social praxis. The apparatus that is Surveillance Capitalism is overreaching and changing our behaviours because of its strength that is accumulated through inequality of wealth, knowledge and resources. As we have seen in the first chapter, the crisis of the Covid-19, has reinforced the dependency of the individual to his or her online and virtual world where all this scheme is today at play. Also, virtual “spectacles” are emerging as a great way to affect people apprehension of the real and have let place to a sense of self-referentiality and narcissism in the communication sphere. In that sense, as De Vries shows we are adopting more and more a “bystander attitude” towards climate change, social changes and economic changes. This phenomenon is also linked to what Zuboff explains lengthily in her book, that our data and online behaviours are actually used against use and might indeed foreclose any real social praxis. Further researches would need to point the actual changes brought about by “the fourth revolution” and our new “pavlovian” addiction to technology. Here might lie the point of this thesis, in showing that the news media which is produced by people that are increasingly becoming both subjects and object of news and are over-emotional might work against the common good. The problem of passivity might well be in that kind of “echo-chamber situation” that works through vicarious consumption and does not let space for any

rational and democratic debate. Today "social values" emerge from the individual but are not being redistributed to them through a genuine social praxis enacted collectively and it might be one of the biggest changes of our current area. A genuine social praxis would consist of a concentration of knowledge combined with a will to act (action). Today it is problematic to see how that might happen as we become more and more individualized, atomized and therefore alienated from ourselves, from our world and from one another. Another point would also be to look at behaviour modification as Zuboff rightly shows. If it is right to decry a system that wants to control and modify behaviours, it is also possible to imagine a society where inform citizens would reject such a system. The asymmetrical knowledge as pointed by Zuboff is also a power struggle, and people could contest it somehow. Because soon one of our last freedom might just be the freedom to think and to live in your own reality. As someone states in the documentary by Jordan Brown- *Stare Into The Lights My Pretties* (2017), the question might be technocracy vs. democracy?

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